7.14 Prehistoric barrows as archive for future research, The Netherlands

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Introduction

As in many other countries in north-western Europe, there are a lot of prehistoric barrows in the Netherlands: at a rough estimate, about 3,000 barrows are known. This number is still growing due to discovery of new elevations on Lidar images, which – after evaluating – are recognized as anciently thrown up mounds, very possibly new, unknown barrows (Fig.69).

Most of these mounds were erected from the Late Neolithic onwards up to the early phase of the Iron Age, from 2900-800 BC. They were built with sods cut in the vicinity of the grave monuments, for instance from heather land, and usually stacked upside down.

The majority of the barrows are situated on the sandy soils in the northern, eastern and southern parts of the country, especially in the provinces of Drenthe, Overijssel, Gelderland, Utrecht and Noord-Brabant. A few dozens of barrows have also been discovered in the Holocene parts of the Netherlands, especially in the West-Frisian region in the province of Noord-Holland. These Holocene 'wetlands' are characterised by favourable preservation conditions, where vulnerable remains such as wood or unburned bone are embedded in moist clay layers. The skeletal parts of the deceased in these parts of the Netherlands are often well preserved whereas the inhumation graves on the sandy soils are deteriorated to a point where only discolourations remain visible. The acidic soils let the unburnt bodies fade away to soil silhouettes at best.

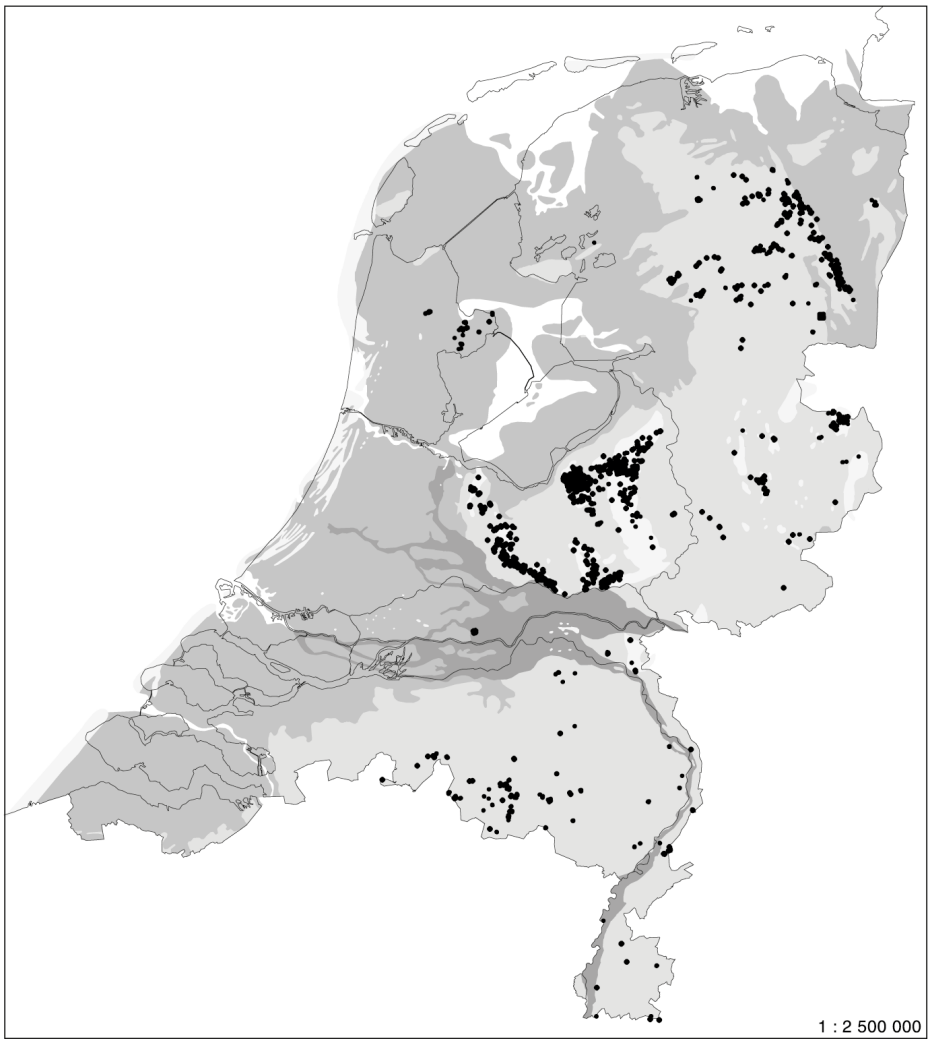

Figure 69: Overview of the visible barrows in the Netherlands. Most barrow groups are situated on the sandy soils in the east and south of the country. (Courtesy CulturalHeritage Agency of the Netherlands)

Figure 70: Typical small-scale excavations of barrows. (left) , the ditch and bank barrow of Hoogeloon-Zwartenberg (RM 45713), in 1950. In remaining crossbaulks the vertical structure of the stacked sods is noticeable. (right) one of the seven mounds (Zevenbergen) near Laren (province of North Holland), carried out in the early 1950s by a handful of workers. (Courtesy CulturalHeritage Agency of the Netherlands)

As regards the treatment of the body, relatives decided either to bury the corpse (inhumation) or to burn it on a pyre and then bury the remains (cremation). The custom of cremating the deceased grew during the Bronze Age, although inhumation was still practised.

More than a century of assessment

Thanks to their visibility, Bronze Age barrows in the Netherlands have always attracted a lot of interest, and they consequently have a long research history. JH Holwerda, curator of the National Museum of Antiquities, was the first scholar to carry out the scientific barrow excavations in 1906, by invitation of Queen Wilhelmina. From 1947 onwards a lot of barrows were threatened by extensive heathland reclamation projects. The archaeological institute of the University of Groningen and the National Service for Archaeological Investigations in Amersfoort managed to excavate many of them (Fig.70). This emergency research carried out by these institutes was on a small scale, involving the investigation of the barrow and the peripheral structure over a couple of days. The work was done by hand. The biggest expense was the wages for the workers who moved the sand with shovels and wheelbarrows.

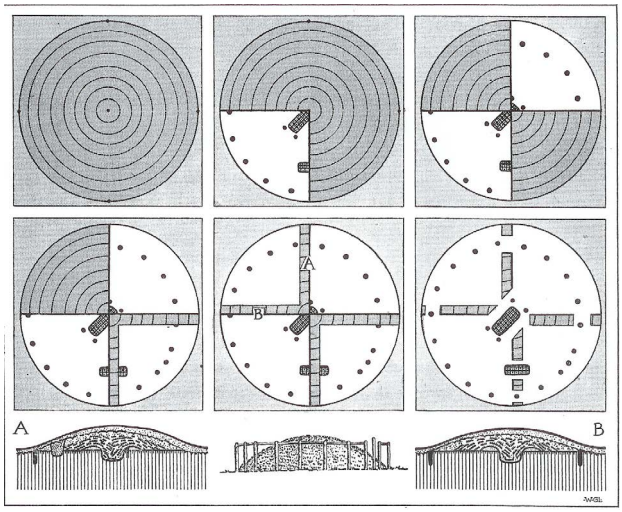

Figure 71: The kwadrantenmethode allows studying and recording the various features and layers in both horizontal planes and vertical profiles, all with great care (Glasbergen 1954).

The so-called kwadrantenmethode (quadrant method) was first applied to excavation of barrows in 1916 (Fig.71). Digging up mounds in this way gave researchers a good insight into the distribution of traces and the vertical structure and layers of the mound. Viewed from above, a barrow is divided in quadrants, which are excavated in quadrants, one by one. The central cross remained in situ; these are the so-called profile dams, the crossbaulks.

Potential for future research

In post-war years the excavators were already aware of the barrows' potential for future research. They cared about the conservation of the excavated tumuli. The remaining parts of the crossbaulks might allow renewed study of the sections, further analysis of the structure of both the mound and the old surface, and sampling. Palynological examinations of the old surfaces under barrows, for instance, can reveal the

Figure 72: A re-evaluation of a restored barrow in 2016, with the original features of the post circle still clearly visible. (Courtesy CulturalHeritage Agency of the Netherlands)

vegetation history. In the case of the barrow group at Toterfout-Halve Mijl near Veldhoven, the excavator W Glasbergen (1954) not only left the crossbaulks intact, he also left most of the post circle features undisturbed. A lot of barrows were often carefully restored after excavation (Fig.72).

The undisturbed parts of the mounds were the main reason for placing many of the excavated barrows under the protection of the Monuments and Historic Buildings Act, which was introduced in 1961. The designation of scheduled monuments in this early period did not involve evaluation and selection. Visibility and expert judgement (by the provincial archaeologists) were the main criteria. Each designation was viewed and assessed in the field. Measurement of the dimensions was done by counting the number of steps, later with a measuring wheel was used.

The scheduled area included the dimension of the visible mound of the barrow with a 10m buffer. Barrow excavations showed that this strip of 10m contained important features, such as the peripheral structures, ditches with bank, ring ditches or post circles. An open area was also desired from an aesthetic point of view (Fig.74).

Figure 73: Many burial mounds are located in forest areas, such this barrow near Putten (scheduled archaeological monument 341245), in the Veluwe area. Most of them are managed by nature organisations. Shoots of young trees and shrubs are removed on a regular basis. (Courtesy CulturalHeritage Agency of the Netherlands)

Heritage management of burial landscapes

In the 1980s and 1990s, the focus shifted more to restoring the mounds, and sometimes - even more radically – reconstructing them. For this, local sand was often used, to replenish parts of the mound that had been eroded and also to raise it. Those extra layers formed a protection for the intact parts, so that they were more resistant to, for instance, motocross racers, dogs, badgers and wild boars. Only a few mounds were 'opened' in these years, mostly to retrieve information about their age. This growing focus on heritage conservation led to protocols for maintenance and management. Barrows still in fact account for the majority of scheduled monuments (c.1550) in the Netherlands.

Nowadays, most of the scheduled prehistoric burial mounds are situated in nature conservation areas, far away from the built environment (Fig.73). These burial landscapes are managed by a number of Dutch nature organisations, for instance by the State Forest Service (Staatsbosbeheer), taking care of 260.000 ha and a considerable number of scheduled monuments. It's a world of balancing between protecting, managing and using the landscape.

In the developer-led archaeological projects sometimes the remains of (unknown) barrows are encountered, such as two barrows excavated within the framework of the road construction of the Westfrisiaweg in Noord-Holland. One of them was 'hidden' below a Late Medieval dwelling mound. Another, quite spectacular discovery is the ritual Bronze Age landscape of Tiel-Medel, investigated preceding the building of a new industrial estate. In the vicinity of an open-air sanctuary three barrows were found where the remains of 60 people were buried; men, women and many children. This research will reignite discussions about barrows and their buried communities and generate new research questions in the Netherlands.

Figure 74: The protected area of the barrow with bank and ditch of Hoogeloon (scheduled archaeological monument 45713) and a 10 metre strip of the direct vicinity (blue circle). (Courtesy CulturalHeritage Agency of the Netherlands)